



WHAT SETS THE POLE VAULT APART FROM OTHER ATHLETICS EVENTS IS THAT SPECTATORS ALREADY KNOW, EVEN BEFORE THE TASK IS ATTEMPTED, EXACTLY WHAT IS BEING ACCOMPLISHED



In the men's shot put, Ryan Crouser has Joe Kovacs pushing him all the way. Sydney McLaughlin-Levrone has Femke Bol in her rearview mirror in the women's 400m hurdles. Noah Lyles might call himself the "fastest man in the world", but the gap between him and last place in the men's 100m sprint was just 0.12 seconds.

Mondo, however, is in a league of his own.

With his first vault, Mondo officially registered a mark in the men's pole vault competition. With his third, he placed himself on the podium. With his fourth, he won an Olympic gold medal.

With his fifth, he broke the Olympic record, clearing 6.10m. For his sixth vault, he had the bar set at 6.25m, a new world record. These six vaults were spread out over three hours.

The rest of his competitors had been fighting their own battles. They had bunched up at 5.85m, trying desperately to break through into the 5.90m medal zone. While all this was happening, Mondo, a solitary figure in a bright yellow jersey, simply sat and observed.

As they squabbled amongst themselves for silver and bronze, he'd clap supportively at their attempts and watch the other races taking place on the purple track

around him.

Mondo knew his battle would come later. It wasn't with anyone else but himself.

He missed his first attempt at 6.25m. In his second, he seemed to have got the height right but not the distance — he landed almost on top of the bar rather than going over it. He did the calculations and discussed it with his coach in the stands. If Mondo was getting the height but not the horizontal distance in his jump, the solution was to bring the bar closer to him.

He adjusted the uprights that hold the bar in place, moving them forward horizontally, reducing the distance between him and the line where he planted the pole into the ground from 70cm to 62cm. His coach had wanted the bar brought even closer, to 60cm from the line.

Had the adjustment not been correct, Mondo would have landed on the bar yet again. But this is an athlete in supreme control of his body.

So, eight centimetres it was, which would be the difference between an already great day and one that can be counted among those defining Olympic moments that occur just a handful of times in each generation.

His competitors might have been hyping up the crowd, but as Mondo

lifted his pole at the start of his run-up, the crowd went silent.

Then, as he sprinted down the track, the stadium groaned in anticipation with each step.

Sam Kendricks, the two-time World Champion who also took silver in Paris, was later asked what makes Mondo special.

Kendricks said, "One, he's had a great coach for a long time and he's been training for a long time. He's got great equipment and understanding of the event. He's a fan of the sport. And (four) he's got God's hand on his back."

The American was referring to Mondo's incredible speed down the runway that allows him to put more energy into the pole than all the rest.

But he may have as well been referring to that mysterious force that separates the legendary athletes from the great ones.

As Mondo sprinted down the runway, it indeed felt like he had God's hand on him.

He bent the pole and went upside down as it thrust him skyward. The uprights being closer to him meant that when he bent his body, it curled perfectly over the bar. What seemed like an eternity later, he began his descent.

After breaking the record, he jumped up from the foam pit, ran towards the photographers, and made the pistol finger gesture — a callback to the Turkish shooter Yusuf Dikec, whose raw dog shooting style went viral in the first week of the Olympics.

Mondo too had his own viral moment. He had his childhood fantasy fulfilled. "If I go my entire life and never have another moment like this, I'll be happy," he said.

It's hard not to marvel at how fitting his nickname was in this moment. As the words *Record du Monde* (French for 'world record') lit up the stadium's big screen, Mondo's achievement felt almost destined.